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The broadcast equipment was boxed up. The chairs were covered and stacked. The centre of attention — the nine-foot-long, five-foot-wide, two-and-a-half-foot-high table — was disassembled. As the clock approached midnight on June 15, the indoor stadium at the EKA Arena in Ahmedabad was on the verge of complete dismantling.

For 16 days, the temporary venue

had hosted the sixth season of the Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) league, which ended with the crowning of a new champion, U Mumba, after its 8-4 win over Jaipur Patriots in a summit clash between two first-time finalists.

The franchise-based league, staged under the aegis of the Table Tennis Federation of India (TTFI) and promoted by Niraj Bajaj and Vita Dani, had previously been held in Mumbai, Pune, New Delhi, Kolkata and Chennai. Ahmedabad's selection as the latest host served two purposes — reaching a new live

Maiden glory: U Mumba was crowned UTT Season 6 champion for the first time after defeating Jaipur Patriots in the final. VIJAY SONEJI

audience and furthering the city's emergence as a hub for Olympic sports, particularly in the context of India's bid for the 2036 Summer Games.

In the previous season, held at the Jawaharlal Nehru Indoor Stadium in Chennai after the Paris Olympics, the majority of the 2,000 available seats were empty on most matchdays. In Ahmedabad, the capacity was halved for a more intimate setting. The cheapest ticket was priced at Rs 49, while premium hospitality ones went up to Rs 1,999.

ATTRACTING MORE GLOBAL STARS AND TOP COACHES DOESN'T SEEM TO BE A CONCERN FOR UTT. INDIAN PADDLERS HAVE SHOWN MARKED IMPROVEMENT IN INTERNATIONAL RESULTS SINCE THE LEAGUE'S INCEPTION IN 2017

Corporate tournaments were held as part of a pre-event local activation campaign, but as with UTT 5, there were days when the EKA Arena looked sparsely populated.

The recent tension between India and Pakistan, following the terror attack in Pahalgam, led to a rescheduling of the Indian Premier League (IPL) playoffs — one of the biggest events in Indian sport. The Eliminator (June 1) and the IPL Final (June 3), both held in Ahmedabad, clashed with two of the first four days of UTT 6. On both days, UTT hosted single ties starting at 5pm, two-and-a-half hours before the IPL matches — but the stands were nearly empty.

From June 4 to 7, a state-ranking